



Scanner Maintenance

General maintenance

- Place your scanner away from heating vents or windows, or other locations where moisture might affect its functioning.
- Always keep the scanner on a level surface so that it gets a good grip, otherwise the mechanism carrying the CCD and fluorescent lamp will get damaged over a period of time.

Cleaning your scanner

- If you find that the images you are scanning are marred with artefacts, light or dark stripes or a chequered board pattern, its time you cleaned your scanner glass. Unplug the scanner and raise the front lid. Apply a very mild streak-free cleaner to a soft lint-free cloth and clean the glass. Never use abrasives, Isopropyl alcohol, benzene or acetone on the scanner glass as this will streak and cloud the glass and can even cause damage. Wipe the glass dry with a soft cloth; wait until it completely dries out. If you find that the glass is dirty underneath, on the inside, do not unscrew the lid to clean it. Instead, call the authorised service centre to get it cleaned.

Moving a scanner

- When transporting a scanner, ensure that the transportation lock is enabled as this prevents the CCD array mechanism tray from moving. To activate the lock, turn off the scanner and push down the lock, which is located at the back of the scanner. Remember to unlock the scanner before you attempt to operate it, else you may end up damaging it.

ed them to return a perfect 5 in this test, but were disappointed as the HP ScanJet 5400C managed only 3 points, with the rest of the high-end scanners scoring 4.

Warranty and support

Not one manufacturer provided a repair warranty for more than one year. Providing a large service network and support across cities helps to a certain extent but the lack of a three-year repair warranty is hard to justify.

HP has the largest service network in this country—it claims to have over 230 service centres across 79 Indian cities. It provides a carry-in warranty on its scanners and the best thing is that a scanner will be replaced or repaired within 48 hours. With such a wide network you generally wouldn't face a problem getting your scanner serviced.

What it all leads to...

Whether you need a scanner for professional use, or simply for scanning your personal photos at home, there's a wide range of scanners available in the market, catering to a cross-section of needs. Here are the best of the lot in performance as well as value for money.

Budget scanners: Despite a price cap of Rs 6,000, we received 11 scanners in this segment. Competition was fierce but there is little doubt about who wins the Best Performance Award—the **Microtek ScanMaker 3800** is probably the best scanner you can purchase for under Rs 6,000. It has a good set of features and returned consistently good performance in our speed and quality tests. It had the fastest black and white text scanning speed and passed the IT8 card test with flying colours. The Best

Value Award goes to **BenQ S2W 3300U**. Its scores are pretty average, but with a price tag of Rs 3,900 there is little that one could complain about—it is a 'no-frills-no-thrills' scanner at a rock bottom price. Nonetheless, it gets the job done and is ideal for users who don't care what shade of red the scanner really scans!

Mid range scanners: We received seven scanners in this segment. The **Umax Astra 4400** won the Best Performance Award—its performance in the quality tests was exceptional. With great photograph scan capabilities, a high dynamic range (colour and greyscale) and excellent support for high resolution scanning, this scanner is a tough one to beat. The **Agfa SnapScan 1212P** bagged the Best Value Award. It costs just Rs 6,500 but offers a good balance of performance and features, with our only gripe being that it uses a parallel port.

High-end scanners: These scanners represent the true pocket pinchers, performance demons and feature-packed monsters. They are targeted at professionals, imaging studios, design houses and corporates. The **HP ScanJet 5470C** won the Best Performance Award. It can scan photographs without artefacts or noise at high resolutions (supports 2400x2400 dpi) and has excellent colour reproduction capabilities. The Best Value Award was taken by the **HP ScanJet 5400C**. It too supports a 2400x2400 dpi resolution but is almost Rs 5,000 cheaper than the 5470C. Though it scores really well in the photo quality and colour tone tests, it performed below par in our resolution test.

The Winners!

Microtek ScanMaker 3800: The ScanMaker 3800

from Microtek is equipped with five one-touch buttons which make the task of scanning very simple. It is capable of scanning at 600x1200 dpi at 48-bit colour depth and sports a USB interface. This budget scanner performed exceptionally well in all the speed tests and gave the mid range scanners a run for their money. It comes bundled with Adobe Photoshop LE and Adobe PhotoDeluxe for editing the scanned images and ABBYY FineReader Sprint OCR to convert your valuable information into editable digitised formats. The scanner is priced at Rs 5,500, which makes it a little pricey for its category, but given the performance, it's worth the price.



Microtek ScanMaker 3800: the best possible combination of speed and quality

BenQ S2W 3300U: The BenQ S2W

3300U has a rated resolution of 600x1200 dpi with 48-bit colour depth and works using a USB interface. Though not the fastest, it returned pretty decent scores in the benchmarks. Its TWAIN driver allows you to make basic corrections such as adjusting highlights and gamma from within the interface itself. Priced at Rs



BenQ S2W 3300U: its price is irresistible